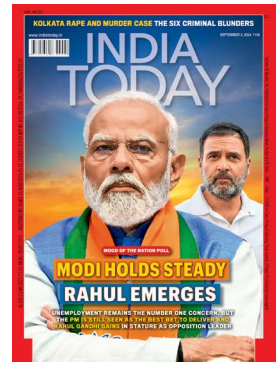
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

IN last year's Lok Sabha election, the Narendra Modi government was nudged from its comfort zone. The catchy slogan of "*char sau paar*" (400-plus) envisaged a domineering majority. Eventually, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) won only 240 seats, 63 less than in 2019 and 32 short of a majority on its own. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) got its historic third term but only as a coalition with just 293 seats. Dependent on demanding allies for the first time, Modi was forced onto the back foot to navigate the dynamics of coalition politics. But that rare moment of vulnerability is truly past. The BJP learned from its setback and shed its overconfidence. Subsequently, a thaw with its ideological mentor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), revived last-mile connectivity for the party's formidable electoral machine. The result was a trio of utterly emphatic assembly poll victories in Haryana, Maharashtra and Delhi, which delivered to the BJP the aura of unshakeable national dominance it desired.



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The latest India Today-CVoter Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey tracks this remarkable comeback that sees Modi fully recovering his mojo. If a general election were to be held now, the BJP would win a comfortable majority on its own, with a tally of 281, a gain of 41 seats. The NDA combine would amass a formidable 343 seats, close to its 2019 peak of 353. The Congress-led Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc seems to have paid the price of complacency after winning a creditable 234 Lok Sabha seats last summer: its tally drops to 188. The Grand Old Party is the main defaulter; its numbers dwindle from 99 seats to 78. The biannual MOTN reflects the NDA government's renewed solidity in satisfaction ratings of 62.1 per cent, up from 58.6 per cent in August 2024. Modi's personal ratings gild this turnaround: 62 per cent say his performance as prime minister is either outstanding or good, 50.7 per cent think he has been the best PM ever, and 51.2 per cent even feel he is best suited to be the next PM. The only notable point of comparison is Rahul Gandhi; all other contenders languish in the single digits. Those who pick the Congress leader as the next PM has risen from 22.4 per cent in August to 24.9 per cent now. These are Rahul's best figures outside of the two MOTNs conducted in the run-up to the 2019 general election, a rise even from August. However, with the Congress's skills at hara-kiri, he appears like a charioteer without a *rath*.

Nevertheless, a perceptible gap lingers between the Modi government's armour-plated aura and its governance report card. Asked for its single most significant achievement, the Ram temple takes the highest spot with 15.2 per cent; political stability comes in next; all growth outcomes trail behind. Both attainments are prone to diminishing returns at a time when economic worries are expected to take centre stage. The MOTN reconfirms unemployment and inflation as India's two biggest problems; they also figure as the Modi government's biggest failures in the public eye, though ticking a range lower than before. The survey reflects an overall pessimism on the economic front: a good 56.9 per cent believe the situation would either stagnate or get worse. That's a slide back from 50.6 per cent in August.

Worryingly for the government, some 62.7 per cent feel their economic status has either stayed static or worsened in the Modi years. Only 26.5 per cent feel their household incomes will improve in the next six months; 33.8 per cent foresee no change, and 31.2 per cent fear it will worsen. Budget 2025, though, receives a thumbs up from 68.1 per cent of the respondents; 43.6 per cent also foresee savings on account of the income tax exemptions. Surprisingly, however, even though 813 million people are getting free food rations in addition to other welfare measures for the poor, the Modi government cannot shake off the perception that its policies benefit big business. The proportion of those who believe so stands at 51.2 per cent. Though a sharp fall from 58.3 per cent in August, this figure has not dipped below 50 per cent in six MOTN cycles.

Encouragingly for the Modi government, the public reposes faith in it as the best hand at the ship's helm for turbulent seas ahead: 52.3 per cent peg its handling of the economy as outstanding or good. The public assents to questions allied to Hindutva: 72.6 per cent favour a Uniform Civil Code, 68.9 per cent back intervention on Waqf lands, and 57.9 per cent endorse petitions reopening temple-mosque disputes. Yet caution would be wise. A majority also back RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's call to end the temple-mosque disputes. Others disapprove of the political use of agencies like the Enforcement Directorate and frown on the perceived diminishing independence of the judiciary. They also want statehood restored for Jammu and Kashmir. The precarious state of collective economic well-being is highlighted by the fact that an overwhelming 82 per cent feel India must have a universal basic income scheme. The government's priority has to be to fix the nuts and bolts of the economy and secure livelihoods, as Hindutva may have limited traction in the years to come. The renewed mandate for Modi 3.0 that the MOTN reveals, in implicit and explicit ways, is for it to go boldly forward with reforms and deliver big on growth. For the Opposition, there is a clear message, too: the killer instinct is not to be practised on the self.

(Aroon Purie)